

HOSTAGE TO VOTEBANKS

The long lost Srikrishna Commission report has returned to become more of a political gimmick than a justice-seeking issue for the Mumbai riot victims



■ By Prerana Thakurdesai

As the media went berserk over Sanjay Dutt's conviction, three words—Srikrishna Commission Report—suddenly caught the fancy of the nation's polity. Tossed around by successive governments, the implementation of the report, which probed the 1993 Mumbai riots, has suddenly assumed an importance greater than it was ever accorded. The entire controversy at this juncture, however, seems nothing more than a political rhetoric though pressure is mounting from all quarters including the media and the Supreme Court on the state Government to

implement the report.

After being commissioned by the Congress government in 1993 in the wake of the communal riots, Justice B.N. Srikrishna Commission Report was first tabled before the Sena-BJP government on August 6, 1998. The report clearly indicted Sena heavyweights Bal Thackeray, Manohar Joshi and Madhukar Sarpotdar for fanning the riots that left 600 Muslims and 300 Hindus dead. Since the government wasn't obligated to implement the report, it was shot down as "anti-Hindu". Several human rights groups have, since then, pressed for the implementation of the controversial report that has implicated 31 policemen.

PLAYING POLITICS: Deshmukh (R) with Uddhav and Bal Thackeray (L); 1993 Mumbai riots (top)

The hullabaloo has now given rise to a number of questions—why, after nine years of silence, has the report suddenly been brought into limelight? According to sources, the Government thought it apt to dig out the report to pacify those who felt the 1993 bomb blasts verdict was anti-Muslim.

The TADA court handed out death penalties to 12 of the 100 convicted, most of who happen to be Muslims. Agrees senior advocate Mahesh Jethmalani, "It seems like the Government has become defensive about the bomb blasts convictions and